Lesson 26: Present Tenses in Writing

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 11 Expressing Meaning in Present Tenses.

In this lesson

You will learn how to choose and form the four present tenses (simple present, present progressive, present perfect and present perfect progressive) by starting with your meaning and matching your time words. You will take a pretest (do Practice 1 before you read the rules), correct paragraphs about money and parking, complete paragraphs about hobbies and write a short letter about a hobby. Academic writing uses these tenses all the time: the simple present for facts and the present perfect for situations from the past up to now.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose a present tense by meaning, and make the time words, tense and verb form match.
- Form the simple present correctly ("be" verb or "do" verb, -s with he/she/it, no -s after does).
- Use the present progressive for actions now and in the present period, but not with non-action verbs.
- Use the present perfect and present perfect progressive for situations that started in the past, actions at an unspecified past time, and repeated actions.
- Find and correct present-tense errors in a paragraph.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
simple present	base verb (the verb with no to, -s, -ed or -ing), or base verb + -s for he/she/it	Money plays an important role in society.
present progressive (pro·GRES·sive)	am/is/are + verb-ing	The professor is checking our homework now.
present perfect	have/has + past participle (the third form: gone, written, loved)	Jiali has loved stamps since she was a child.
present perfect progressive	have/has + been + verb-ing	She has been accumulating stamps for over ten years.
"be" verb / "do" verb	am, is, are / every other main verb	Money is important. / Money plays a role.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
non-action verb	a verb for a state, not an action: feelings, thoughts, senses, possession (know, need, see, look, have, cost); not used in progressive tenses	The parking lots at my college look full.
time expression, frequency adverb	words that show time (now, since, these days) or how often (always, usually, never)	My sister and I usually go shopping on the weekends.
convey (con·VEY)	verb: express, show	The purpose of communication is to convey meaning.
guarantee (guar·an·TEE)	verb: promise, ensure	Does money guarantee happiness?
sibling (SIB·ling)	noun: a brother or sister	taking care of a younger sibling
addictive (ad·DIC·tive)	adjective: becoming a habit, cannot stop	addictive computer games
accumulate (ac·CU·mu·late)	verb: gather, collect	How many years has she accumulated stamps?
pursue (pur·SUE)	verb: follow with great interest	How long have you been pursuing it?

Rules and explanations

Three principles

1. **Start with meaning.** Ask: What ideas am I trying to express?
2. **Tense and verb form are an inseparable pair.** For current activities, use a present tense, not a past form with -ed.
3. **Time words are like traffic signs.** Time words, tense and form must match: do not use "yesterday" for an event in progress now.

Simple present

1. With am/is/are as the main verb, use no "do" verb; with a "do" verb, use no am/is/are. Not "Money is plays an important role" but "Money plays an important role"; not "People are use different currencies" but "People use different currencies". Every sentence needs a verb: not "Money useful in people's lives" but "Money is useful in people's lives."
2. He/she/it + a "do" verb: add -s. "Many people save money because it gives them a sense of security."
3. In questions and negatives with does/doesn't, leave off the -s: "Does money guarantee happiness? No, it does not."

- **Meaning 1: facts and truths.** Often with always, constantly, frequently, usually, often, generally, sometimes, seldom, rarely, hardly ever, never. "The Department of Treasury manages

the currency in the U.S."

- **Meaning 2: current habits, routines, repeated activities.** Every day, each night, once a week, twice a day, on Tuesdays. "My sister tries to save money on many things, but she does not save money on shoes."

Present progressive: am/is/are + verb-ing

- **Meaning 1: happening at the moment of speaking.** Now, right now, at the moment, at present. "Is Eva sitting next to Maria?"
- **Meaning 2: happening during the present period.** Currently, today, these days, nowadays, this semester. "More students are working out in the new fitness center these days."
- It can also show future plans (Lesson 34, Future Tenses in Writing).
- **No non-action verbs.** From Lesson 5: feelings and thoughts (believe, know, like, love, mean, need, prefer, understand, want), the five senses (appear, feel, hear, look, see, seem, smell, taste), possession (belong, contain, have, own) and others (cost, find). Not "The parking lots at my college are looking full" but "... look full" (the book's example in Exercise 2).

Present perfect: have/has + past participle

- **Meaning 1: started in the past, continues till now, may go on.** Since, for, recently, lately, so far, to date, till now, in the past/last two weeks, today, these days, this week, all life. "Jiali has loved stamps since she was a child."
- **Meaning 2: completed at an unspecified time in the past.** Already, before, just, never, yet (sometimes no time words). "Jiali has just joined a stamp-collecting club at her college." "The gifts have not arrived yet."
- **Meaning 3: repeated in an unspecified past time or since a past time, and may happen again.** Once, two times, a few times, many times. "So far, she has gathered over five hundred stamps from different countries." "She has attended the club meeting three times since the beginning of the semester."
- Irregular past participles: Appendix D (Lesson 29).

Present perfect progressive: have/has + been + verb-ing

- **Meaning 1:** the same as present perfect Meaning 1, **with more emphasis**. "Jiali has been collecting stamps since she was ten years old."
- **Meaning 2: still going on, with no time expression.** "The stamp club has been expanding."
- No non-action verbs here either: "has loved", not "has been loving".

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic present-tense sentences need no "be", so "Money useful" is a common error. English always needs a verb: "Money is useful."
> - Arabic has no present perfect and uses the present tense with "since/for". English needs the present perfect (progressive): not "She is waiting for ten minutes" but "She has been waiting for ten minutes."

Practice

1. Pretest (Section I). If the verb in bold is correct, choose "correct". If not, choose one of the other answers.

1. Money **play** an important role in the society. a) correct b) is play c) plays
2. Another name of money **is** currency. a) are b) being c) correct
3. People **are use** different currencies in different countries. a) correct b) use c) uses
4. For example, the U.S. dollar is the currency in America, and the euro **was** for some European countries. a) are b) correct c) is
5. When someone travels to a foreign country, he or she **had** to exchange the currency. a) correct b) has c) have to
6. My friend Rubina **exchanging** money at the airport right now. a) correct b) exchanges c) is exchanging
7. She **been waiting** in line for ten minutes. a) correct b) has been waiting c) is waiting
8. In the past two weeks, she **is** excited about her upcoming trip to the Dominican Republic. a) correct b) has been c) was
9. Rubina **do not want** to spend her vacation at home. a) correct b) does not want c) no wants
10. A vacation out of the country **is costing** more money, but it is worth it. a) correct b) cost c) costs

2. Book Exercise 1: "Allowance – Beneficial or Not?" Read the paragraph in your lesson material. Find ten more verb errors (not including the example, "receiving (receive)") and correct them.

3. Book Exercise 2: "Seeking a Parking Space". Read the paragraph in your lesson material. The writer is looking for a spot right now. Find five more errors with the simple present and present progressive (not including the example, "are looking (look)") and correct them.

4. Book Exercise 3: "An Unusual Hobby – Toy Voyaging". Read the paragraph in your lesson material and fill in the blanks with the simple present or the present perfect (not including the example, "bring"). The blanks, in order: (1) give, (2) invent, (3) try, (4) become, (5) show, (6) travel, (7) no cost.

5. Book Exercise 4: "Antoni's Hobby". Read the paragraph in your lesson material. Underline the verbs in each sentence. For each sentence, write the tense and its meaning (use the meaning numbers in this guide). Then explain the paragraph to your tutor.

6. Book Exercise 5: "My Hobby: Writing Diary". Fill in the appropriate verb tenses in the paragraph in your lesson material. The blanks, in order: (1) save, (2) like, (3) happen, (4) write, (5) read, (6) feel, (7) keep, (8) stay, (9) not, need, (10) be, (11) make, (12) worry, (13) not, like, (14) feel, (15) write, (16) keep.

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me ten questions about money and hobbies that need different present tenses, one at a time. Correct my verbs and tell me which meaning I used."

- "Check my answers to Exercise 1, 'Allowance – Beneficial or Not?', in the lesson material."
- "Let me explain the difference between 'He has fixed things for ten years' and 'He has been fixing things for ten years.' Tell me if I am right."
- "Here is my letter: [paste]. Underline every present verb and tell me if the tense matches my meaning and my time words."

Read aloud

Mark the -s ending sound: /s/ after voiceless sounds, /z/ after voiced sounds, /ɪz/ after s, z, sh, ch, j sounds.

1. Money plays /z/ an important role in society.
2. Many people save money because it gives /z/ them a sense of security.
3. The amount of money starts /s/ from a few dollars a week and increases /ɪz/ as the children grow.
4. Many parents believe that the allowance helps /s/ the children learn the value of money.
5. The Department of Treasury manages /ɪz/ the currency in the U.S.

Writing task

Book Exercise 6. Write a letter (to a friend, or to your tutor) of about 150-200 words on one topic:

- What is your favorite hobby? How long have you been pursuing it? Why do you like it? Do you enjoy it alone or with other people?
- What do you think are some of the reasons why some people do not have a hobby? Can people remain happy without a hobby? Why or why not?

Use all four present tenses at least once, each with a matching time expression.

Self-editing checklist:

- Every sentence has a main verb.
- I never put am/is/are before the base form of a "do" verb ("is play").
- He/she/it + "do" verb has -s; after does/doesn't there is no -s.
- I used the present progressive only for now or the present period, and never with a non-action verb.
- I used the present perfect (progressive) with since, for, so far, already, yet, and so on.
- My time words, tenses and verb forms match.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- The source of Exercise 3, "ToyVoyagers" on Wikipedia (archived copy; the article has since been removed): http://web.archive.org/web/20211117202342/https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/ToyVoyagers

Answer key

1. (book): 1. c) plays 2. c) correct 3. b) use 4. c) is 5. b) has 6. c) is exchanging 7. b) has been waiting 8. b) has been 9. b) does not want 10. c) costs ("cost" is a non-action verb).

2.

1. Some children getting it → get
2. most children does not need → do not need
3. The amount of money start → starts
4. and increase as the children grow → increases
5. if a child be five years old → is
6. Many parents are believe → believe
7. the allowance is help the children → helps
8. other parents does not agree → do not agree
9. Why my children need money? → Why do my children need money?
10. which group of parents are right → is right (the subject is "group", singular)

3.

1. Many students are try → are trying
2. I circling → I am circling
3. I am seeing an empty space → I see (non-action verb)
4. another car taking it → another car is taking it
5. I am needing → I need (non-action verb)

("parting lot" is a spelling error for "parking lot", not a verb error.)

4. (book) 1. give 2. have invented 3. tried / have tried 4. have become 5. have shown 6. have traveled 7. does not cost / doesn't cost

5.

- **is** (Doing ... is Antoni's hobby): simple present, Meaning 1, a fact. ("Doing" is a gerund, a verb + -ing used as a noun, here the subject; it is not a tense.)
- **has been fixing** (for ten years): present perfect progressive, Meaning 1, with emphasis.
- **has fixed** (for ten years): present perfect, Meaning 1; the same meaning with less emphasis.
- **did, got married, moved** (for two years ... three years ago): simple past, finished at a specific past time.
- **has not changed** (all these years): present perfect, Meaning 1.
- **has cleared, (has) replaced, (has) installed**: present perfect, Meaning 2, completed at an unspecified time.
- **has resolved** (So far ... for at least twenty families): present perfect, Meaning 3, repeated and may happen again.

- **has been sealing** (These few weeks): present perfect progressive, Meaning 1, still going on.
- **jokes**: simple present (a current habit or fact); **are working** (Now): present progressive, Meaning 1.

6. (book) 1. saves 2. like 3. has happened / happened 4. write 5. read 6. feel 7. keeps 8. stay 9. do not need / don't need 10. are 11. makes 12. worry 13. do not like / don't like 14. feel 15. have been writing / have written 16. has kept / has been keeping

My notes